

A FEMALE CRUSOE.

AN INDIAN WOMAN EIGHTEEN YEARS ALONE ON THE ISLAND OF SAN NICOLAS, OFF THE COAST OF SOUTHERN CALIFORNIA. PHYSICAL CONDITION GOOD ; RECOLLECTED EVENTS, BUT HAD LOST ALL KNOWLEDGE OF THE COMPUTATION OF TIME AND THE DIALECT OF HER TRIBE.

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I well recollect with what boyish pleasure and absorbing interest I followed Robinson Crusoe in his lonely travels and daily occupations on the island of Juan Fernandez, little thinking that in later years I would find a similar case on this far-off coast ; but such is the fact, and my narrative is not only based upon facts, but is fact, the knowledge of the circumstances having been obtained from the discoverers, captors and the attending physician during the last sickness of my feminine "Crusoe," the heroine of San Nicolas Island.

Having heard that an Indian woman had lived a lonely life of eighteen years—from 1835 to 1853—on one of the many islands off this coast, I was anxious to learn more about it than the varying and contradictory reports in general circulation gave me, but was unable to do so until about two years ago, or a short time previous to the publication of my first article on this subject, much of which is here rewritten, when in person I visited Mr. George Nidever and Mr. Chas. Deitman (usually called and known by the name of "Charley Brown"), two of the party which brought her from the island to this place, and Mrs. Nidever, who had charge of her after she landed. Mrs. Nidever was consulted through an interpreter conversant with the Spanish language. Mr. Nidever is well advanced in years, seventy-eight, but retains his faculties to a good degree. A frontiersman from early life, he spent many years as trapper and huntsman among the Indians of the Northwest previous to coming here in 1835. He became expert in the use of the rifle, and maintains his reputation even to the present day ; without the aid of glasses he can put a pistol-ball into the head of a gopher at twenty-five feet. Although an American by birth, he usually converses in Spanish, the language of his wife and family.

Mr. Nidever said in substance : "My occupation has been that of otter-hunting. When I came here, in 1835, I found two other Americans, Isaac J. Sparks and Lewis T. Burton, engaged in the same business. They chartered a schooner of twenty tons burden, built at Monterey, called *Peor es Nada* (Better than Nothing), for a trip to the coast of Lower California, on another expedition, leaving Santa Barbara about the first of May, 1835. I did not accompany them. Not being as successful as those in charge expected, three months later the *Peor es Nada* put into San Pedro, the port, or landing, of Los Angeles, on her return trip. From San Pedro she went to the Island of San Nicolas, about seventy miles southwest from San Pedro and a little further southeast from Santa Barbara, for the purpose of removing the Indians then on the island to the main land, and returned with eighteen men, women and children, as told me by Isaac J. Sparks. How long the Indians had been residents of the island, how

they got there, and by whose authority they were removed, I know not. One of the Indians, rather dwarfed in intellect, but possessing physical strength equal to three or four ordinary men, remained at San Pedro; two of the women were taken as concubines by two Americans living in Los Angeles County; the balance of the party divided, part going to Los Angeles and part to San Gabriel Mission. Those two men who selected their concubines from the party took an active part in having the Indians removed from the island."

According to the information I have obtained from those consulted, the history of the Indian woman is as follows: She was absent gathering wood when the others were taken away, but returned to the camp or quarters, and, finding them deserted, followed in time to be taken aboard the schooner; but, not finding her children there, one a babe at the breast and the other about three years old, she plunged into the water and swam ashore in search of them. Unable to find her children, she returned to the beach just in time to see the schooner leaving. She called to those on board, but the only reply she got, and which she remembered to the day of her death, was "mañana," pronounced mah-nyah-nah, the Spanish word for "to-morrow," evidently meaning that the schooner would return for her to-morrow or the following day. She threw herself down on the beach and cried long and bitterly. She did not find her children, and supposed they were either taken off with the others or carried away and devoured by the wild dogs on the island. She became very sick, and lay a long time (she could not compute time) without either water or food, but finally recovered, and forgot her grief in wandering about the island. She lived on a plant resembling the cabbage, called by Californians "palosanto," and a root known by the name of "corcomite;" also a yellow root, the name of which was not given, and seal or sea-lion blubber. As she had abalone-shell fish-hooks, and lines made of the sinews of the seal, it is probable she supplied herself with fish from the ocean.

An approaching storm, and night coming on, the water being quite shoal about the island and unsafe for a vessel during a high wind, those in charge of the *Peor es Nada* were compelled to leave for the safety of the ship, intending to return at a future time for the deserted woman. The vessel ran before the gale and reached San Pedro harbor in safety. But circumstances did not permit a return prior to the loss of the schooner in a storm a few weeks later, and the distance to the island was too great to be safely made in the small shore boats.

In 1851 Mr. Nidever visited the island otter hunting, and saw signs of a human inhabitant. He saw a footprint made during the previous rainy season, sunken deeply in the now dry, hard ground, and, from the size, judged it to be that of a woman. Also three small circular enclosures, about two hundred yards from the beach, and about a mile apart. They were about six feet in diameter, made of brush, the walls five feet high, with a small opening on one side. Near these openings were sticks of drift-wood stuck in the ground in the form of a tripod, supporting dried seal-blubber. These enclosures appeared to be simply wind-breaks, affording no protection from the rain. The investigation was pursued no further, as an ap-

proaching storm compelled them to leave the island. Mr. Nidever, having seen many otters on his first trip to the island, made a second during the winter of 1852, and being requested by the Mission Fathers of Santa Barbara, had determined to make a careful hunt for the supposed lone inhabitant of the island. The head of the island being better supplied with fresh water closer to that portion of the beach affording the best facilities for fishing, and the altitude such as to command a view of the greater portion of the island and coast, he supposed, if alive, she would be found there, and made his arrangements accordingly. He and his party found the same, or similar, enclosures above mentioned, and the tripod sticks supporting renewed pieces of blubber. In the neighborhood of the huts, or wind-breaks, were seven or eight wild dogs, about the size of a cayote (a small wolf on this coast), and in color, black and white. Mr. N. said he had seen the same kind of dogs among the Northwest Indians. They appeared to be very wild. Within half a mile of the head of the island they discovered a basket in the crotch of a bush, or small tree, covered with sealskin, and containing a dress made of shag's skins (the shag is a species of duck that can neither walk nor fly), carefully folded up, and several square pieces of skin similar to those of which the dress was made, a rope made of seal sinews, abalone-shell fish-hooks, bone needles, etc. As it was late, and time for them to return to their boat for the night, Mr. N. scattered the contents of the basket on the ground, so that on his return he could judge of the presence or absence of the owner, by finding them gathered up or remaining as he left them. The following four or more days were busily spent in otter hunting, and before the search for the Indian woman was renewed a southeast gale compelled them to seek a more hospitable harbor at the island of San Miguel. A third voyage by Mr. N. and six others, four of whom were Indians from Santa Barbara Mission, was made to the island in July, 1853; and, although otter hunting was the main object of the visit, the Indian woman was not forgotten. They landed on the northeast side of the island early in the day, and having selected their camping site, all but one—the cook—started for the head of the island.

Near there were observed fresh footprints leading from the beach to the ridge, or higher elevation, but were soon lost in moss-covered ground, which ended the search for the day. The following day they were more successful. One of the party, Mr. Deitman, discovered the object of their search at a distance, and cautiously approaching in an opposite direction from the balance of the party, got quite close to her without being observed. She was in one of her pens, or wind-breaks, clothed in a garment made of the skins of the shag, without sleeves, low-necked, and, as observed when standing, extending almost to the ankles. She was sitting cross-legged, skinning seal-blubber with a rude knife made of a piece of hoop-iron driven into a piece of wood. There was no covering on her head, excepting a thick mass of matted hair of a yellowish-brown color, due to its exposure to the sun and air. The hair was short, looking as though the free ends had rotted off. She would occasionally raise her hand, shade her eyes and look towards the beach, where she evidently saw those from whom Mr. Deitman had recently separated. There were two or three of

the wild dogs around the enclosure, which began to growl as Mr. Deitman approached, but ran off at the bidding of their mistress. The balance of the party were now signaled, in order that she might be captured if she attempted to escape. To the surprise of all, she made no attempt to get away, but greeted each one as he approached with a bow and a smile, and chattered all the while in a dialect which none of them understood, although the Indians accompanying Mr. Nidever were acquainted with several Indian dialects. She was talking apparently to herself from the time Mr. Deitman approached within hearing until she was made aware of his presence.

Within the enclosure a fire was smouldering, and a large ash-pile outside showed that to have been her abiding-place for some time. She was very hospitable—preparing a meal from her limited store of roots before named, and serving the party with a grace and bearing that surprised them all. The expression of her face was pleasing, and her features were regular. Her complexion was much fairer, and her form more symmetrical than that of the Indian women on the main land, and she is believed to have belonged to a different and superior race, which opinion is strengthened by the fact that Mons. Leon de Cessac, a Frenchman, now engaged in collecting archæological and other specimens of bygone years on the Pacific coast of North and South America for a Paris museum, has found many things on the island San Nicolas similar to those previously collected in Oregon, Washington Territory, and further north, and unlike anything found either on the main land or the other islands. Also, the skulls and other bones of the human skeleton found there are unlike those found in other sections of Southern California. A notable observation is the absence of any evidence of syphilis, a striking contrast with other human bones found in this latitude. I have had the privilege of examining several skulls exhumed on other islands, showing very plainly the ravages of this disease in those who have passed away probably centuries ago. Near her enclosure were several stakes, between which was stretched a rope made of the seal's sinews, supporting seal and sea-elephant blubber. Further on were three huts, made of whale's ribs, covered with brush, but giving no evidence of having been lately occupied. By signs, and other means of communication, she was made aware that they wanted her to accompany them, and without any apparent hesitation, she made ready to follow. She filled a basket—such as were common among the Indians of this coast for packing on their backs—with provisions, fishing-tackle and other articles, and taking it on one arm and a firebrand in the other hand, she followed the company.

In their course to where the schooner lay at anchor, they found a beautiful spring of water issuing from the bank above the beach, under a shelving rock. The cracks or fissures in this rock were stuck full of bones, and there were other evidences of an encampment of the lone inhabitant of the island. These bones were used for nourishment, obtained by sucking; they had been dried and resucked many times, showing that, occasionally, she was put upon short rations; but at the time of her discovery, appeared to have an abundance, such as it was. She retained all her teeth, but they were worn low—supposed to be due to the chewing of tough and solid articles

of food. Her age appeared to be about fifty years. Further on was another spring, near the beach, under the bank. Here she indicated a desire to bathe, and was permitted to do so by the balance of the party retiring out of sight. After her bath she joined the others and went direct to the shore-boat, and thence to the schooner. She was prevailed upon to abandon her firebrand and seal-blubber before leaving the beach. Going aboard the vessel, she went directly to the stove and warmed herself, indicating that she knew its use. She ate heartily of the food of the crew, appeared to enjoy it, and it agreed with her. Mr. Deitman made her a skirt of ticking, with which, and a sailor's cotton shirt and a black necktie, her attire was complete. She assisted in making her dress, but could not see to thread her needle. Her sewing was quite rude. She appeared much pleased with her new apparel. The following day she went ashore with the men, who made a separate shelter for her, which she occupied about a month—the time spent on the island otter hunting. She was quite industrious, carrying wood and water without its being required of her. She appeared contented and happy, frequently singing and chattering to herself. The men could not understand what she said, nor she they; but Mr. N. said it was truly wonderful how she could converse with them by signs. She occupied a portion of her time making water-vessels of grass and asphaltum—a substance plentiful both on the islands and shore of the main land. The grass was plaited into a shape resembling a demijohn, but wider at the top, and lined with asphaltum. She would put in several small pieces of the last-mentioned substance, then drop on them small pebbles or stones about the size of hulled walnuts, heated sufficiently to melt the asphaltum, and, grasping the neck with both hands, the lower end being on the ground, would give it a rapid rotary motion for several minutes, and then empty the stones on the ground.

The vessels had a continuous coating on the inside, and are reported to have been water-tight, the lining even resisting the heat of the sun when covered with water. She had both stone and earthen vessels in which to boil water and cook, if desired. To procure seal-blubber, she could kill the seals with a club, when on land, sunning themselves, or snare them with her sinew ropes. She obtained fire by rubbing two dry sticks together. One of them, partly flat, had a groove along its entire length; the other was pointed and fitted into the groove, in which it was rubbed rapidly backward and forward until it burned. As usual, a storm compelled the party to leave the island, and, embarking with their island queen, they soon found themselves at sea in a storm. She made signs that she could stop the storm, and obtaining permission, knelt on the deck facing the quarter whence the wind came, and commenced muttering something supposed to be a prayer. She soon got up, and continued the prayer at intervals during the day, apparently without fear; and when the wind began to abate, she turned to her fellow voyagers, and, with a smile, made signs that her prayers had been answered.

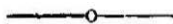
When they came in sight of Santa Cruz Island, off this coast, she told them by signs what it was, and indicated how she had seen from her island ships pass up and down, but never land, and how, the day previous to her discovery, she had seen the Nidever party pass to the

head of the island. She was afraid to make herself known until she knew that there was no danger to her person. There were many places of concealment on the island, and unless taken unawares, she would have been hard to find.

As she was about to land at Santa Barbara an ox-team passed, which so delighted her that she talked, laughed, danced and gesticulated ; and before that excitement ended, a man on horseback approached, which gave her even more pleasure than the ox-team. At first it was supposed that she thought the man and horse constituted one animal ; but if so, the mistake was soon corrected ; for, on landing, she went up to the horse and carefully examined it. The examination gave her additional pleasure. She would turn to her late companions and laughingly request them to look at the beast. She straddled the thumb of the left hand by the index and middle fingers of the right, and moved them to represent the horse and rider as they passed along the beach. She was taken to the house of Mr. Nidever, where she became the centre of attraction. The Mission Fathers took a great interest in her—sending to Los Angeles and other places, hoping to find some one who understood her dialect, but failed. Even the Pepimaros Indians, who were said to have had an acquaintance with the Indians on the island, could not understand her. The family of Mr. N. became very much attached to her, and although the captain of the brig *Fremont* offered largely for the privilege of taking her to San Francisco and placing her on exhibition, it was refused. Also an offer of a thousand dollars from another party for a like purpose was refused. Many people called on her and she received them kindly ; but the afternoon was her favorite time for receiving calls, when she would put on her shag-skin dress and entertain her callers with a song and a dance. She cared nothing for money—giving it to the children when given to her. She did not wish to sleep in a bed ; and when in bed, did not desire bed-covering ; but was careful not to expose her person. Her manners were not rude, and in many things she was more refined than many who enjoy civilized privileges ; yet in many things she was very much like a child. She wanted everything which she saw that appeared pleasant to the eye, or seemed good to the taste ; and if fruit was withheld from her she would plead for it in such a childlike manner that it was hard to refuse her. When found, she was in excellent physical condition, strong and active ; but the eating of fruit and vegetables brought on a diarrhoea or dysentery in about three weeks after she landed ; and that, in connection with an injury to the spine, received by falling from a porch, terminated her life four weeks later, or seven weeks from the time she landed. During her sickness she reluctantly permitted her kind hostess to dress her in flannel underclothes, and took her bed under proper covering ; but positively refused to return to her former plain diet, as was proposed by some of those who called to see her. Her dress of shag-skins, basket and trinkets were given to Father Gonzales, of the Mission, who, it is said, sent them to Rome.

Statistics in civilized life show a greater longevity in the marital and social relations than in celibacy and the life of the recluse ; but here is one who had attained the age of fifty years with a physique indicating that a period in the future might be reached equal to that

of the past, that for eighteen years had been absolutely alone. With the exception of the sickness immediately after her desertion, she reported no illness during the time of her exile. She appeared to enjoy perfect health, with no failure of any of the bodily functions, excepting that of sight, which may have been either hypermetropic or presbyopic; if the former, most likely it was congenital; if the latter, it may have been hastened by the little use made of the power of accommodation for near objects—she daily cultivating the power of distant vision, in commanding a view of the island and looking seaward. The extremes of heat and cold are unknown on the islands off this coast; frost is seldom seen in the winter, and the heat of summer is not oppressive, owing to the ocean winds, which give a most equable climate the year round, favorable to an outdoor life. During the rainy season she probably took shelter in a cave, or under shelving rocks, as found upon the island; but be that as it may, the vicissitudes of the weather did not appear to affect her unpleasantly. Her outdoor life gave a digestion equal to the use of the seal blubber, and her supply of the small variety of vegetables assisted in nourishing her without deranging the secretions. On this island, estimated at fourteen miles in length and averaging about four in width, its highest elevation being not more than six hundred feet above sea level, but sparsely timbered, with its rocks, sandy plains and limited vegetation, clear spring water, which invited repeated ablutions, with no roof to intercept the welcome rays of the sun, our *Female Crusoe* possessed and used the means conducive to a long life. But the change from such a life to one of more luxury and indolence soon demanded the penalty of the violated laws of health—*sickness and death!*



What Kills.—In the school, as in the world, far more rust out than wear out. Study is most tedious and wearisome to those who study least. Drones always have the hardest time. Grumblers make poor scholars, and their lessons are uniformly “hard and too long.” The time and thought expended in shirking would be ample to master their tasks. Sloth, gormandizing and worry kill their thousands where over-study harms one. A curse rests on laziness and gluttony. By the very constitution of our being they are fitted to beget that torpor and despondency which chill the blood, deaden the nerves, enfeeble the muscles and derange the whole vital machinery. Fretting, fidgeting, *ennui* and anxiety are among the most common causes of disease. On the other hand, high aspiration and enthusiasm help digestion and respiration, and send an increased supply of vital energy to all parts of the body. Courage and work invigorate the whole system, and lift one into a purer atmosphere, above the reach of contagion. The lazy groan most over their “arduous duties,” while earnest workers talk little about the exhausting labors of their profession. Of all creatures the sloth would seem to be the most worried and worn.